

Incident Alert 0027. TLP CLEAR.		Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU, U.S. UA – Fool Me Once: Russian Influence Operation Doppelganger Continues on X and Facebook	05/09/2024	2

Summary

- In June 2024, inauthentic X-accounts published 1.366 posts matching the Russian influence operation Doppelganger posting pattern on X.
- The posts were then amplified in replies to third-party posts and replies.
- The pattern was found in German, French, English, Italian, Polish and Ukrainian.
- According to X data, the combined views of these posts reached over 4.6 Million.
- The posts try to undermine support for Ukraine and feeding polarisation in the countries they targeted.
- 98 Facebook ads with pro-Russian content targeted France, Germany, Poland, and Italy within the same month.
- Platforms contacted – X no known response.

Incident

From June 4th to 28th 2024 1.366 accounts published 1.366 pro-Russian posts on X (formally Twitter), which were then amplified by many additional accounts in replies to third-party content. The pattern was found in German, French, English, Italian, Polish and Ukrainian. The observed activity bears multiple markers of previously attributed Doppelganger activity, including narratives, technical infrastructure and posting behaviours.

On July 15, 2024, the activity, then encompassing 1.236 posts, was flagged to X, with 623 posts still online. By August 23rd, only one of the 623 accounts that prior to our flagging to X had been online was suspended. Additionally, 98 Facebook ads with pro-Russian content were found targeting France, Germany, Poland, and Italy within the same month.

Civil society and the European Commission have alerted Meta and X about the tactics and techniques of Doppelganger. At the time of writing, the threat is ongoing on the platforms.

At the time of writing, X has not responded to us alerting them about posts. There was no need to alert Meta about the Facebook ads as the associated pages that posted the ads were taken down, or are no longer in use.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Cease Ukraine support.

Sub-narratives: Discrediting Western governments and political parties, supporting pro-Russian parties, fear mongering of inflation, economic demise, polarising narratives localised to the specific countries. .

Impact

Reach: According to X data, the combined views of these posts reached over 4.66 Million by the end of June. Authentic-appearing replies to some of these original posts suggest a breakout to level 2.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Smear](#) - Smear EU member state governments and Ukraine.

Objective: [Discourage](#) - The influence operation is trying to discourage the targeted countries to support Ukraine.

[Post Inauthentic Social Media Comment](#) - Inauthentic accounts use quote tweets to comment on other users' posts.

[Conceal Network Identity](#) - The X accounts are not revealing that they are part of a larger network, posing as authentic users.

[Conduct Server Redirect](#) - The posts contain redirect URLs to either direct users to operational content if they are the target audience or show them an irrelevant website.

[Purchase Targeted Advertisements](#) - On Meta's platform, DG also purchased targeted unlabelled political ads to reach their target audience

Recommendations

- Action taken: CIB network reported to X 15/07. – pending response. Report sent to Meta – 03/09.
- Reported to EU Institutions, the targeted EU member states.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Ukraine, Polarisation	Upon request	Lea Frühwirth, CeMAS Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe Dominik Uhlig, BIQdata.pl / Gazeta Wyborcza Charles Terroille, Science Feedback Max Lesser, FDD (Foundation for Defense of Democracies) Ivana Stradner, FDD. Claudia de Sessa, Alliance4Europe Lorenzo DiStasi, freelance journalist Kateryna Savranska, Demagog Aleksy Szymkiewicz, Demagog Oleksandr Siedin, Detector Media Oleksii Pivtorak, Detector Media Florian Roussel, independent researcher	X posts, Meta Ads	X, Meta
			Paul Bouchaud, AI Forensics.		